solidarity, the diplomatic scaffolding for this duty was often provided by Ambassador Panikkar from his post in Beijing.

Convinced that China and India shared the common ground of Asian identity, Panikkar's impressions of Mao's humanism and China's receptivity to India's friendship provided the subtext for regular reports to Nehru confirming the warm state of Sino-Indian relations and China's continuing goodwill towards India – as evidence of which he often cited trivialities such as Premier Zhou Enlai and other dignitaries attending parties at his house or important members of the Foreign Office being courteous to him at public events.[37] Panikkar's reports, often a lesson in vacuity, deftly propagated the idea that the People's Republic 'demonstrated the resilience of Asian civilization, its ability to incorporate Western knowledge and develop a sense of nationhood that could defeat colonialism in Southeast Asia.'[38]

The other force that shaped India's foreign policy outlook was Nehru's profound ambivalence, even distrust, towards the United States and the West in general. His state visit to the United States in October 1949 had been a disappointment, despite the warm reception from President Truman (who sent his personal aircraft to ferry him) and constructive talks with Secretary of State Dean Acheson. American hopes that India might consider becoming a part of collective security arrangements in Asia had been dashed, in spite of Nehru's proclamations of 'natural friendship'. Indian hopes of getting a million tonnes of wheat as food aid had been belied, notwithstanding private assurances from Truman and Acheson. To top it all, Nehru and his hosts had disagreed on the question of the recognition of the People's Republic of China, and the Indian Prime Minister had expressed his hope that the United States would not mind if he publicly criticized its approach to China.[39]

This distrust was exacerbated by the state visit of Liaquat Ali Khan in May 1950, which Nehru read as a sign of American indifference to his international role and a deliberate attempt to accord prestige to Pakistan.[40] Concurrently, China had continued to carry out 'a vigorous campaign of